

EXPLORERS AND EXPLORATIONS

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter students will be able to:

1. Explain the reasons for exploration.
2. Identify key past explorations and explorers (Marco polo, Ibn-e-Battuta, Neil Armstrong, Vasco De Gama, etc.).
3. Identify the effects of past explorations.
4. Trace the route of any voyager on a world map.
5. Identify what motivated past explorers to conduct exploration.
6. Construct a third person account of the experiences of any explorer.
7. Explain the success and challenges faced by the explorer of their choice.
8. Predict areas of future exploration and changes that could result from these explorations.

EXPLORERS AND EXPLORATIONS

Throughout history people have always wondered what was beyond the next mountain, how did people in other countries live, what is it like on the moon. Throughout history there have also been people who actually went to new places to find out about them. These people are known as explorers.

The history of the world is filled with explorers, brave men and women who set out into the unknown in search of knowledge and wealth. Even today they are people who continue to explore and make new discoveries in different areas of knowledge.

WHY DO PEOPLE EXPLORE?

There are many reasons why people go on explorations. Some of them are given below:

- i. **Trade:** The rulers of many countries supported explorers in the hope that they would find new trade partners, new trade routes and new goods to trade. This was the case of Vasco da Gama and Christopher Columbus.
- ii. **Gold:** Often explorers have been in search of riches and treasure. The Conquistadors were primarily searching for gold and silver when they conquered the Native Americans.
- iii. **Science:** In many cases, explorers are scientists hoping to learn more about nature. They may be hoping to find a new species of animal or a new type of plant.
- iv. **Land:** Many explorers claimed the land they found in the name of their country. Countries like Spain, Portugal and Great Britain amassed huge empires during the Age of Exploration.
- v. **Challenge:** Many explorers want to test their personal abilities and be the first in the world to do something. These types of explorers include the people who raced to be the first to the North and South Poles, the top of Mount Everest, and to the Moon.



Do you know?

The Age of Exploration or the Age of Discovery took place between the 15th and 17th centuries AD. During this time many countries in Europe sent out explorers to discover new lands, find trade routes, seek treasure, and gain territory for their country. During this time much of the world was mapped and many world civilizations came into contact with each other.

Activity

What motivated explorers in the past to go on explorations? What motivates explorers today?

World Famous Explorers

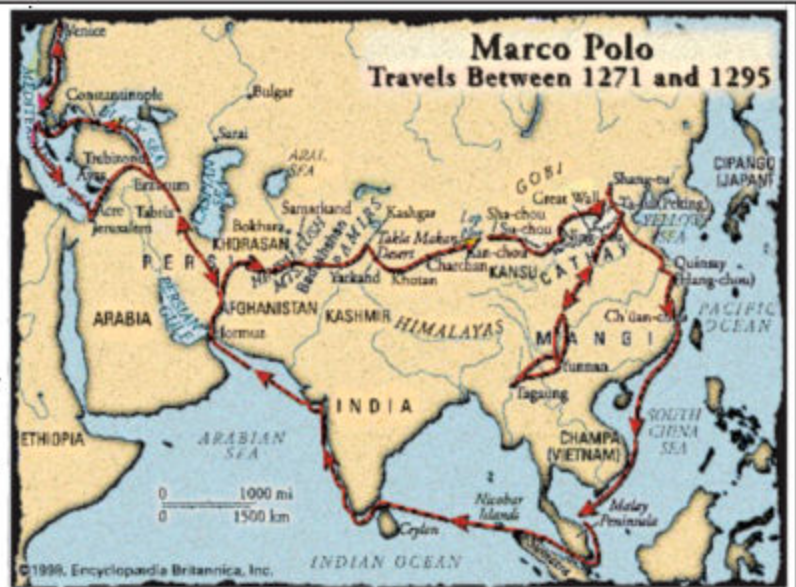
In the next few pages we will learn about some famous explorers including Marco Polo, Ibn-e-Battuta, Christopher Columbus, Vasco da Gama, Edmund Hillary and Neil Armstrong.

Marco Polo



Marco Polo

- **Occupation:** Explorer and Traveler
- **Born:** Venice, Italy in 1254
- **Died:** January 8, 1324 Venice, Italy
- **Best known for:** Travels to China and the Far East



Marco Polo was a merchant and explorer who traveled throughout the Far East and China for much of his life. For many years, his stories were the basis for what most of Europe knew about Ancient China.

Venice was a wealthy trading city and Marco's father was a merchant. Not many people had traveled all the way to China in those days. Marco's father and uncle wanted to try something different. They wanted to travel all the way to China and bring goods from China directly back to Venice. They thought they could make their fortune this way. They travelled to China in 1260 and returned 9 years later in 1269.

A few years later, in 1271 they left for China and Marco went along with them. They arrived in the court of Kublai Khan the ruler of China three years later. Along the way Marco visited many great cities and saw many sites including the holy city of Jerusalem, the Hindukush mountains, Persia, and the Gobi Desert. He met a lot of different people and had many adventures.

Marco lived in China for many years and learned to speak the language. He traveled throughout China as a messenger and spy for Kublai Khan. He even traveled far south of China to where Myanmar and Vietnam are today. During these visits he learned about different places, peoples and cultures. He saw many places and things that no one from Europe had ever seen before. Everything from the food, to the people, to the animals, like orangutans and rhinos, were new and interesting. Marco was fascinated by the wealth and luxury of the Chinese cities and of Kublai Khan's court. He had not seen anything like it in Europe.

After twenty years of traveling, Marco, along with his father and uncle, decided to head home to Venice. They returned home in 1295 AD. A few years after returning home, Venice fought a war with the city of Genoa. Marco was arrested. While he was under arrest, Marco told detailed stories of his journeys to a writer who wrote them all down in a book called, *The Travels of Marco Polo*.

The Travels of Marco Polo became a very popular book. It was translated into many languages and read throughout Europe. After the fall of Kublai Khan, the Ming Dynasty took over China. They were very suspicious and distrustful of foreigners so there was little information about China available. This made Marco Polo's book even more popular.

Activity

Look at the map showing Marco Polo's travels. Look at a map of the world today and name all the places he visited.

Ibn-e-Battuta



Ibn-e-Battuta

- **Occupation:** Explorer and Traveler
- **Born:** Tangier, Morocco in 1304
- **Died:** Around 1377 in Morocco
- **Best known for:** travelling across all the continents of the world, over a span of 25 years.



Muhammad Ibn-e-Abdullah Ibn-e-Battuta was born in Tangier, Morocco, in 1304. He belonged to the Berber tribe and is considered to be one of the great travelers of the world. In 1325, at the age of 21, he set off for *Hajj* to

Do you know?

Ibn-e-Battuta's traveled more than 75,000 miles across the world.

Makkah. He travelled over land, following the North African coast. The route took him through Algiers and Tunis. In 1326, Ibn-e-Battuta reached Egypt and then went to Syria, where he joined a caravan travelling to Medina. After a few days in the holy town, he went to Makkah and performed Hajj.

Ibn-e-Battuta wanted to explore, learn, write and teach. From Makkah, he embarked on a journey that continued for 25 years. During these years, Ibn-e-

Battuta visited most of the known Muslim world as well as many non-Muslim lands. His journeys included trips to Eastern Europe, Middle East, South Asia, Central Asia, Southeast Asia and China. He also visited Delhi at the time when Muhammad Tughlaq was ruling India. Since, Ibn-e-Battuta was a jurist of Islamic Fiqh, the King appointed him as a Qadhi (Judge).

Activity

On a World map mark all the places visited by the great traveller Ibn-e-Battuta.

Christopher Columbus



Christopher Columbus

- **Occupation:** Explorer
- **Born:** 1451 in Genoa, Italy
- **Died:** May 20, 1506
- **Best known for:**
Discovering America



Christopher Columbus is the explorer who is credited with discovering America. Of course, there were already people living in America at the time who we call Native Americans. There were also other Europeans who had been to the Americas before. However, it was Columbus' voyage that started the exploration and colonization of the Americas.

Columbus worked as a trader in Lisbon where he learned to make maps and navigate a ship. Columbus and his brother, Bartholomew, knew that there were great riches to be had in China and East Asia. However, traveling over land by the Silk Road was dangerous and a sea route around Africa seemed too long. Columbus thought he could sail straight to China by crossing the Atlantic Ocean. It turned out that Columbus was wrong. There was another land, the Americas, between Europe and Asia.

Columbus spent years trying to convince someone to pay for his voyage. Finally, he was able to convince Queen Isabella and King Ferdinand of Spain to pay for it.

He set sail on August 12, 1492 with three ships named the Nina, the Pinta, and the Santa Maria. The voyage was long and difficult. His men threatened to mutiny if he did not turn back. Columbus promised them he would turn back in two days if they didn't find land. On October 12, 1492 land was spotted. It was a small island in the Bahamas that Columbus named San Salvador. He called the people that he met

there 'Indians' because he was convinced that he had landed on islands off the coast of India.

Upon returning to Spain, Columbus was treated like a hero. He presented some of the new things he had found such as turkeys and pineapples and even some people he had captured to the king of Spain. The King was very pleased and funded future expeditions.

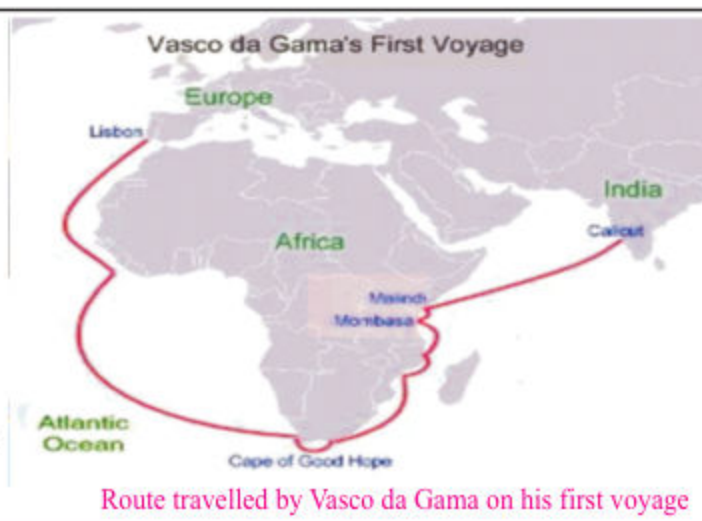
After his first voyage, Columbus made three more voyages to the Americas. He explored more of the Caribbean and even saw mainland America. Columbus died on May 20, 1506 thinking he had discovered a shortcut to Asia across the Atlantic Ocean. He never knew that the land he found was the Americas.

Vasco da Gama



Vasco da Gama

- **Occupation:** Explorer
- **Born:** 1460 in Sines, Portugal
- **Died:** December 23, 1524 in Kochi, India
- **Best known for:** The first European to sail from Europe to India around Africa



Vasco da Gama was born in a small coastal town in Portugal named Sines. His father was a knight and an explorer. He followed in his father's footsteps and soon commanded ships in the King's name.

Spices from India were very popular in Europe; however, the only way to travel from Europe to India was over land. This was a long and expensive trip. The King of Portugal thought that if he could find a way to get to India by sailing on the ocean, he would start trading spices in Europe and become rich.

An explorer by the name of Bartholomew Dias had discovered the Cape of Good Hope at the tip of Africa. Some people thought that there may be a way around the Cape to India. However, many were doubtful and thought that the Indian Ocean did not connect with the Atlantic Ocean.

Vasco da Gama was given a fleet of ships by the King and told to find a trade route around Africa to India. He was also told to find any other trading opportunities along the way. Vasco da Gama left on his first voyage from Lisbon, Portugal on July 8, 1497 with 170 men and 4 ships.

The expedition rounded the southern tip of Africa at the Cape of Good Hope on November 22. They then headed north up the coast of Africa. They stopped at trading ports along the way including Mombasa and Malindi. At Malindi they met a local navigator (guide) who knew the way to India. With the help of a Monsoon wind they were able to cross the Indian Ocean and arrive in Calicut, India in less than a month.

The voyage back from India to Portugal was disastrous. Around half of Vasco da Gama's crew died from scurvy as the trip back took much longer. On returning home, he was given a hero's welcome as he had found the much needed trade route to India.

Vasco da Gama commanded two more fleets to India. The second voyage was more of a military expedition. He captured Arab ships and tried to show the might of the Portuguese navy.

On the third voyage Vasco was to take over as Viceroy of the Portuguese in India. However, he died of malaria shortly after arriving in India.

Activity:

What was the impact of Vasco da Gama finding a sea route from Europe to India on a) Europe and b) India.

Fun Fact

There is a crater named Vasco da Gama on the Moon.

Sir Edmund Hillary

Sir Edmund Hillary was an explorer and mountain climber. Together with Sherpa Tenzing Norgay, he was the first to climb to the summit of Mount Everest, the highest mountain in the world.

Edmund Hillary was born in New Zealand. He became interested in climbing when he was 16 years old and climbed his first major mountain when he was 20. He continued his love for exploring and climbed many mountains in the coming years.

In 1953 the British had received approval to make an attempt at scaling Mount Everest. The government of Nepal would only allow one expedition a year, so this was a big deal.



Sir Edmund Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing Norgay

- **Occupation:** Explorer and Mountain Climber
- **Born:** July 20, 1919 in Auckland, New Zealand
- **Died:** January 11, 2008 in Auckland, New Zealand
- **Best known for:** First to climb Mount Everest

The leader of the expedition, John Hunt, asked Hillary to join in the climb.

When climbing a mountain as high as Mount Everest, a large group of people are needed. There were over 400 members in the expedition. They climbed the mountain in stages, moving to a higher camp every few weeks and then getting acclimated to the high

altitude. At each stage fewer and fewer people continued to climb. Once they got to the final camp, there were two teams chosen to climb the last stage to the summit. One team was Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay. The other team was Tom Bourdillon and Charles Evans. The team of Bourdillon and Evans tried first, but they failed to make it to the top. They got within 300 feet, but had to turn back.

Finally, on May 28, 1953, Hillary and Tenzing got their chance to try for the summit. They ran into some difficulties, including a 40 foot rock wall that is today called 'Hillary's Step', but they made it to the top. They were the first to climb to the top of the world! Because the air was so thin, they only stayed at the top for a few minutes before returning to tell the world of their achievement.



Mount Everest

Neil Armstrong

Neil's love for flying started at a young age when his father took him to an air show. From then on his goal was to become a pilot. At the age of 15, he got his pilot's license.

Armstrong went to Purdue University and earned his bachelor's degree in aerospace engineering. He later got his masters degree at the University of Southern California. During college, Neil was called up by the Navy and became a fighter pilot. He fought in the Korean War where he flew fighters from aircraft carriers. At one point his plane was hit by enemy fire, but he was able to safely eject from the plane and was rescued.

After graduating from college, Armstrong became a test pilot. He flew all sorts of experimental planes testing them out to see how well they flew. It was a dangerous job, but very exciting. He flew over 200 different types of aircraft during his career.



Neil Armstrong

- **Occupation:** Astronaut
- **Born:** August 5, 1930 in Wapakoneta, Ohio USA
- **Died:** August 25, 2012 in Cincinnati, Ohio
- **Best known for:** First person to walk on the moon.



Edwin Aldrin and the US Flag

Armstrong applied to become an astronaut and in September of 1962 he was selected for the NASA Astronaut Corps. He had to go through a series of harsh physical tests, which he passed becoming a NASA astronaut.

On December 23, 1968 Neil was offered the command of the Apollo 11. This would be the first manned landing on the Moon. This was an exciting time for the entire United States. The United States was in a race with the Soviet Union to put the first person on the Moon. If the flight was successful, Neil Armstrong would be that person.

After months of practice and preparation, the Apollo 11 spacecraft was launched from the Kennedy Space Center in Florida on July 16, 1969 with three astronauts on board: Neil Armstrong, Edwin Aldrin and Michael Collins. There was one scary moment in the flight where Armstrong had to take over manual control of the landing. This was not the plan and, if the landing took too long, would leave the crew short on fuel. The landing was successful and upon landing Armstrong said "Houston, Tranquility Base here. The Eagle has landed."

After landing, Armstrong was the first to leave the craft and walk on the Moon. The historic date was July 21, 1969. His famous words upon being the first person on the Moon were "That's one small step for man, one giant leap for mankind". Edwin Aldrin also walked on the Moon during this trip. They were on the moon for 21 hours. They collected moon rocks to bring to Earth. While the lunar module, named the Eagle, was on the Moon, the third astronaut, Michael Collins, orbited the Moon in the command module.



The Apollo 11 lunar module,
the Eagle, on the Moon

The three astronauts who were now heroes arrived back on Earth on July 24th.

Do you know?

- Six hundred million people watched the first person moon walk on the moon on TV.
- The footprints made by Neil Armstrong and Edwin Aldrin are still on the Moon. The dust is thick, but there isn't any wind to remove them.

Samina Khayal Baig



Samina Khayal Baig

- **Occupation:** Explorer and Mountain Climber
- **Born:** 19 September, 1990 in Hunza, Pakistan
- **Best Known for:** First Pakistani woman to climb Mount Everest on 19 May 2013.



The route on Mount Everest image courtesy of www.alanamette.com

Samina Khayal Baig was born on September 19, 1990 in Shimshal Village in Hunza, Gilgit-Baltistan. She began climbing mountains when she was only 4 years old. From the age of 15 she received training in mountaineering from her brother Mirza Ali.

In 2009 she became a professional mountain climber. She was the first to climb the peak Chashkin Sar (above 6,000 meters) in Pakistan in 2010, which was later renamed Samina Peak after her. She reached the summit of 'Koh-i-Brobar' ('Mount Equality') in 2011. On 1 April 2013, Samina Baig and company started climbing the south face of Mount Everest. The expedition to the summit took 48 days, with the mountaineers reaching their goal on the sixtieth anniversary of Edmund Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing's first successful conquest of Everest. This made her the first Pakistani woman to climb the tallest mountain in the world. It also made her the youngest woman in the world to climb Mount Everest.

In 2013 Samina Baig and her brother Mirza Ali decided to climb the seven summits the highest mountains in each of the seven continents of the world. They have accomplished this feat by climbing the seven mountains. Mount Aconcagua in Argentina, the highest peak in South America which is 6,961 m high. Mount Vinson, in Antarctica which is at a height of 4,892 m in the planet's southernmost continent. Mount Everest in Nepal, in Asia which is at a height of 8,848 m. Mount Kilimanjaro in Tanzania on the continent of Africa which is at a height of 5895m. Mount Puncak Jaya in Indonesia which is at a height of 4,884 m. Mount McKinley in Alaska in North America which is at a height of 6,194 m and Europe's highest mountain, the 5,642 m high Mount Elbrus in Russia.



Samina Khayal Baig waving the flag of Pakistan on the summit of Mount Everest

SUMMARY

In this chapter we have learnt about the general reasons for exploration such as for trade, to obtain wealth, to learn more about nature, to acquire land and to challenge oneself. We have also learnt about some important explorers both past and present, their motivations for becoming explorers and the effects of their explorations.

Teacher's Note

While teaching this chapter, you may discuss with students the following points:

- Modern explorers and early explorers are both different and similar. They are similar in these ways: they are all exploring areas unknown, they are exploring for evidence of life. They are different in these ways: they have different tools, different technology, and different locations.
- The early explorers and the modern explorers both explored lands that were unknown to other people. They explore unknown places to look for things that we don't have and for things that we don't know about. They look for plant and animal life too.

Modern explorers have some advantages over early explorers. The modern explorers have much better technology. Modern explorers also explore different locations. They have to explore different locations because the early explorers have already explored areas and they are now well populated and are well developed.

EXERCISE

A. Multiple choice questions

1. For every question, three answers are given; tick the correct one.
 - i. Where was Christopher Columbus born?
 - (a) America
 - (b) China
 - (c) Italy
 - ii. When Ibn-e-Battuta left Tangiers where did he want to go?
 - (a) China
 - (b) India
 - (c) Makkah
 - iii. Who did Marco Polo travel with to China?
 - (a) Brother and Father
 - (b) Father and Mother
 - (c) Father and Uncle
 - iv. Columbus thought he could sail straight to China by crossing the _____ Ocean.
 - (a) Arctic
 - (b) Atlantic
 - (c) Indian
 - v. How many voyages did Vasco da Gama make to India?
 - (a) One
 - (b) Two
 - (c) Three

B. Answer the following questions

- 1) Name three explorers and explain the reason for their explorations.
- 2) What were the effects of Christopher Columbus' voyages to the Americas?
- 3) What do you think will be areas of future exploration and what changes do you think would result from these explorations?
- 4) Select any explorer and explain the successes and challenges faced by him/her.

C. Make a table

1. Make a table like the one below and complete it by finding out information from the chapter you just read and from other books or the Internet.

Name of Explorer	Country they belonged to	What work did they do	What motivated them to explore	What challenges did they face	What was the result of their exploration
Marco Pola					
Ibn-e-Battuta					
Christopher Columbus					
Vasco de Gama					
Neil Armstrong					

D. Practical work

1. Trace the route of one of the explorers of your choice on a World map.
2. Imagine that you are a reporter writing an article for a newspaper/magazine on the adventures of any explorer you have read about. Write the story of that explorer, mentioning adventures, difficulties and successes of the exploration.

E. Extension activities

Find out about an explorer of your choice and write an article on him/her to share with your class.